

CDN Incident Alert: 0045. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	DE RT Deutsch's Amplification Through Podcast Aggregators	20/02/2025

Summary

- RT Deutsch's podcasts remain visible to German-speaking audiences via alternative podcast aggregator networks, bypassing bans on major platforms through open hosting policies. These aggregators host thousands of podcasts, including U.S. government-funded content, making RT Deutsch's presence unlikely to be a coordinated effort. The "podcasts" are audio versions of RT articles, enabling Russian state media to evade text-based content filters and appear in search results.
- Sites hosting RT content reach more than 20 million visitors monthly, though RT DE's podcast likely accounts for a miniscule portion of that traffic. ListenNotes ranks RT Deutsch's podcast in the top 1% most listened to podcasts—drawing substantial traffic, but on par with many obscure podcasts.
- The strategy aligns with DISARM TTPs of bypassing content blocks and search engine manipulation.
- Recommendations: Share intelligence with hosting providers, investigate RT's podcast funding and infrastructure, and analyze how Russian state media exploits audio to bypass filters.

Incident

In early 2025, (likely beginning several years earlier) analysts observed that RT Deutsch's podcast episodes (audio versions of its online articles) continued to appear across numerous podcast-aggregator websites, despite relatively widespread restrictions on RT's broadcasting and social media presence in Germany. These aggregator sites appear to be standard platforms designed to host and catalog thousands of podcasts without editorial oversight. RT Deutsch's decision to repurpose articles into podcasts ensures that its content surfaces in podcast directories, making it more discoverable through search engines and podcast apps that do not generally screen for banned outlets.

Narrative - separate with ;

While not necessarily relevant to the particularities of this incident, over the last three months, RT Deutsch's podcasts have promoted the viewpoint that Western institutions are deliberately suppressing alternative perspectives. Key themes include:

- Claims that the West orchestrates energy deals in Ukraine to undermine local sovereignty and boost United States interests;
- Statements that NATO's activities in the Baltics unnecessarily increase tensions with Russia;
- Accusations that Western governments engage in censorship and use legal mechanisms to curtail dissent on foreign and domestic policies;
- Allegations of Western corruption in aid distribution and attempts at historical revisionism;

Impact

- Estimates based on publicly available web traffic data—the aggregator sites draw an estimated 23 million visitors monthly—suggest that RT Deutsch's content is featured across many aggregator sites, making it accessible to audiences who search for podcasts on political or international topics.
- The podcast format allows RT Deutsch to sidestep restrictions in places where its textual or video content might be blocked.
- Casual consumers may interpret RT Deutsch's presence on multiple podcast platforms as a sign of legitimacy, especially because these aggregator sites also host content from an extensive range of sources, including mainstream organizations.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework) (Max 2 objectives and 4 TTPs).

Objective: Circumvent platform bans and maintain RT Deutsch's audience.

T0121.001 – Bypass Content Blocking: RT Deutsch uses audio-only formats to navigate restrictions on its main broadcasts, making it more difficult for traditional moderation to filter.

T0046 – Use Search Engine Optimization: Hosting many episodes across aggregator platforms boosts RT Deutsch's search ranking, allowing its podcasts to surface in queries where they might not otherwise appear.

Recommendations and Actions Taken (end each recommendation with a ;)

- Coordinate with podcast directory operators to develop transparent guidelines for handling content from sanctioned or restricted outlets.

- Examine the technical and financial underpinnings of RT Deutsch's podcast-distribution strategy. This includes assessing whether third parties are knowingly promoting RT's content or simply providing an open-access platform.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Unrele ased	RT Deutsch; podcasts	N/A	Larissa Doroshenko, Alliance for Securing Democracy; Peter Benzoni, Alliance for Securing Democracy	Websites- aggregators	